Meerut was rather a busy station, leading one of the officers to remark that 'there is no peace in a peace station'. Events followed one after the other with no let-up; operational commitments, professional competitions, sports competitions and administrative inspections, most often with conflicting and overlapping dates. The long-range for firing, for example, would be allotted on the same dates as for the annual inspection of arms (AIA). It seemed the required diligence in staff work was not being done, and no one seemed to be perturbed about it. It forced units to take shortcuts and sometimes fudge their records. Col Ghuman, though, was an absolute stickler, a go-by-the-book kind of person who would cut us no slack. He was hard on himself too, as he tried to get the paltan back into shape. The other officers felt that after a hard HAA tenure, some leeway was warranted. As the 2iC, this put me in a difficult position. The CO would complain to me that the officers and JCOs were not pulling their weight. The officers and JCOs would come to me complaining of their impossible workloads. It fell on me to act as the buffer and keep the paltan going. It also highlighted to me the importance of having the entire team on board when embarking on a new enterprise.

Meerut was even busier for me. As the only staff college-qualified officer in the Brigade, all the central workload fell on me. Umpire for a divisional exercise—Maj Naravane; examiner for Part D promotion exam—Maj Naravane; officer in charge to conduct firing competition—ditto; master of ceremonies for Bogra Day celebrations[1]—*hazir hai* (present, sir)! There were times when I would come back from one assignment in the morning and depart for the next in the evening. This was more than Veena had bargained for and she was quite annoyed with me for being missing all the time. She had the complete right to expect my presence, especially after having been alone in the

Copyright © Penguin Random House India
Not for circulation